TRAINING GUIDE · QUALITATIVE DATA ANALYSIS

ATLAS.ti Qualitative Analysis Guide

Turn interview transcripts, focus group notes and reports into clear, evidence-based findings. A step-by-step guide for evaluators, researchers and M&E teams.

Projects and documents | Quotations | Coding | Code groups | Memos | Reports

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Free learning material

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Each section has learning goals, step-by-step instructions, tips from evaluation practice and a short practice exercise.

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Version note
This guide follows the ATLAS.ti desktop version for Windows and Mac. Button names can differ slightly between versions; the steps and the logic stay the same. Use a set of sample transcripts to follow along.

INTRODUCTION

01 Getting started

BY THE END OF THIS SECTION YOU WILL BE ABLE TO

- Explain what ATLAS.ti is used for
- Find your way around the main tabs
- Name the six main entity types

ATLAS.ti is software for qualitative data analysis. It helps you organize text, audio, images and survey comments, mark the passages that matter, tag them with codes and see patterns across many interviews. In evaluations it is commonly used to analyze key informant interviews (KIIs), focus group discussions (FGDs) and open-ended survey answers.

Import	Read	Code	Analyze	Report
Transcripts, notes	Get to know the data	Tag meaningful passages	Compare and query	Evidence for findings

Starting the program

On Windows, type **ATLAS.ti** in the search box on the taskbar and open it. On a Mac, open it from Applications. The welcome screen lists your recent projects.

The ribbon tabs

Tab	What you do there
Home	Add documents, create codes, memos and networks, and open the managers. Most work starts here.
Search Project	Search across all documents, quotations, codes and memos.
Analyze	Run code co-occurrence, code-document tables, word frequencies and other analysis tools.
Import & Export	Import survey data and reference lists; export code books and project bundles.
Tools & Support	Settings, user accounts, the quick tour and help resources.

The six main entity types

Documents

Your data: transcripts, reports, PDFs, audio, images.

Quotations

The passages you mark as meaningful.

Codes

Short labels that tag quotations by topic or theme.

Memos

Your notes, ideas and early interpretations.

Networks

Visual maps of how codes and ideas relate.

Links

Named relations, such as "explains" or "contradicts".

Each entity type has its own **manager**. Open them from the Home tab: Documents, Quotations, Codes, Memos and Networks.

SETUP

02 Set up your project

BY THE END OF THIS SECTION YOU WILL BE ABLE TO

- Create and save a new project
- Add, remove and renumber documents
- Organize documents into groups

Create a project

1. Click **File**, then **New**, then **Create new project**.
2. Enter a clear name, for example *Endline evaluation, KIIs, 2026*, and click **Create**.

Add documents

1. On the **Home** tab, click **Add Documents**.
2. Select your transcripts or files and click **Open**. They appear in the Project Explorer on the left.
3. Give documents consistent names before import, for example `KII_05_District-Officer_F`, so you can sort and filter later.

Remove documents

Select one or more documents in the Project Explorer, right-click and choose **Delete**. You can also open the Document Manager, select the documents and click **Delete Documents**. If you delete one by mistake, use **Undo** straight away.

To restore a clean, consecutive numbering after removing files, open the Document Manager and use the renumber option.

Group your documents

Create **document groups** for the attributes you will compare, such as respondent type, district or sex: *KIIs*, *FGDs*, *Women*, *Men*. Groups let you compare what different respondents said later.

Save often

Click the **Save** icon in the quick access toolbar, or choose **File**, then **Save**. Export a project bundle as a backup at the end of each working day.

! **Protect respondent identity**
Remove names and other identifying details from transcripts before import, and store project files in a secure, access-controlled folder.

PRACTICE · 15 MINUTES

Start your project

Use the five sample transcripts provided.

- [ ] Create a new project with a clear name
- [ ] Add all five transcripts
- [ ] Create document groups for KIIs and FGDs
- [ ] Save the project and export a backup bundle

FIRST LOOK

03 Explore your data

BY THE END OF THIS SECTION YOU WILL BE ABLE TO

- Use word clouds to get a first overview
- Create and name quotations
- Link related quotations with hyperlinks

Word clouds and word lists

Right-click a document in the navigation panel and choose **Word Cloud** or **Word List**. Frequent words appear larger. This is a quick way to see what respondents talk about most before you start coding. Add common words such as "the" or "and" to the stop list to clean up the view.

Quotations

A quotation is any passage you mark as meaningful: a sentence, a paragraph, a section of audio or part of an image.

1. Open a document and highlight a passage with your mouse.
2. In the ribbon, click **Create Free Quotation**.
3. Right-click the quotation and choose **Rename** to give it a short, descriptive name, for example *Strong example of improved access*.
4. Read the full quotation in the preview field of the Quotation Manager.

Mark strong quotes as you go
Name your most powerful quotations clearly. They become the direct quotes that bring your evaluation report to life.

Hyperlinks between quotations

A hyperlink is a named link between two quotations. Use it when one statement explains, supports or contradicts another, for example a district official's account and a beneficiary's account of the same service.

1. Open the Quotation Manager.
2. Drag one quotation and drop it on another.
3. Choose the type of link, such as **explains**, **supports** or **contradicts**.

PRACTICE · 20 MINUTES

Explore a transcript

Use one KII transcript.

- [ ] Create a word cloud and note the five most frequent words
- [ ] Create and name three quotations
- [ ] Link two quotations that support or contradict each other

04 CODING
Code your data

BY THE END OF THIS SECTION YOU WILL BE ABLE TO

- Create codes and apply them to passages
- Reuse, replace, merge and split codes
- Build a clean, well-organized code list

Two ways to build codes

DEDUCTIVE

Start from your framework

Create codes before reading, based on the evaluation questions or OECD/DAC criteria: relevance, effectiveness, efficiency, impact, sustainability.

INDUCTIVE

Let themes emerge

Create codes while reading, for new ideas respondents raise that your framework did not expect.

Most evaluations combine both: a starting code book from the questions, plus new codes that emerge from the data.

Create and apply a code

1. Highlight a passage in a document.
2. Click **Open Coding** in the document ribbon.
3. Type the code name and click **Create**. You can add several codes to the same passage.

Apply an existing code

Drag the code from the Project Explorer or the Code Manager and drop it on the highlighted passage. Dock the Code Manager on the right of the screen so your code list is always in view while you read.

Replace a code

Drag a different code from the navigator or Code Manager and drop it on top of the code you want to replace.

CODING

04 Organize your codes

Merge codes

Early coding often produces many small codes. To keep your list manageable, merge codes that mean the same thing or belong to one broader theme. Select the codes in the Code Manager and choose **Merge Codes**, then give the result a clear name.

Split a code

If a broad code has collected too many quotations, split it into more precise sub-codes. Think of a basket of mixed fruit: at first one basket is fine, but soon you want separate baskets for citrus, apples and bananas. Select the code and click **Split Code** in the Code Manager.

Code groups and naming

Group related codes, for example all codes about *Effectiveness*. A naming pattern keeps the list sorted:

Code name	What it captures
EFF: Improved skills	Respondents describe new skills gained from training
EFF: Job placement	Getting work after the program
SUS: Community ownership	Signs that the community will continue the activity
BAR: Distance to services	Travel distance as a barrier to taking part
REC: Longer follow-up	Recommendations about follow-up support

Prefixes: EFF effectiveness, SUS sustainability, BAR barriers, REC recommendations.

Write a code book
Give each code a one-line definition in its comment field. When several people code the same project, a shared code book keeps coding consistent and makes your analysis easy to explain.

PRACTICE · 45 MINUTES

Code two transcripts

Use the starting code book from your trainer.

- [ ] Apply the starting codes to two transcripts
- [ ] Create at least three new inductive codes
- [ ] Merge any two codes that mean the same thing
- [ ] Add a one-line definition to five codes

THINKING

05 Write memos

BY THE END OF THIS SECTION YOU WILL BE ABLE TO

- Create memos to record ideas as you analyze
- Link memos to quotations and codes

Memos are where analysis happens. Use them to note early patterns, questions to check, contradictions between respondent groups, and draft wording for findings.

Create a memo

1. On the **Home** tab, open **New Entities** and choose **Free Memo**, or open the Memo Manager.
2. Enter a name, for example *Finding 2: access for women*, and click **Create**.
3. Write your notes in the editor. Date your entries so you can see how your thinking developed.

Link a memo to evidence

When a quotation illustrates a point in your memo, drag the memo from the Memo Manager or the navigator and drop it on the quotation. You will never lose the evidence behind an idea.

USEFUL MEMO

Research diary

One running memo with dates, decisions and changes to the code book.

USEFUL MEMO

One per finding

Draft each evaluation finding with its linked supporting quotes.

USEFUL MEMO

Open questions

Points to check with the team or in further interviews.

RESULTS

06 Analyze and report

BY THE END OF THIS SECTION YOU WILL BE ABLE TO

- Compare codes across respondent groups
- Export coded quotations to Word, PDF or Excel

Useful analysis tools

Tool	Question it answers
Code-Document Table	How often does each theme appear for each respondent group, such as women and men, or district A and district B?
Code Co-occurrence	Which themes appear together, for example *Barriers* with *Distance*?
Query Tool	Find quotations that meet conditions, such as coded both *Effectiveness* and *Women*.
Networks	Show how codes connect in a diagram for a presentation or report annex.

Export a report

1. Open the Code Manager and select one or more codes.
2. Click **Report** on the Codes tab.
3. Choose how to sort the output: by code, by code group or, in team projects, by the person who coded.
4. Select what to include: quotations, comments, document names and memos.
5. Click **Create Report**, then save it as Word or PDF. Use Excel export for tables you will chart.

From codes to findings
For each evaluation question, export the related codes, read all the quotations together, then write the finding in your memo with two or three of the strongest quotes as evidence.

PRACTICE · 30 MINUTES

Produce your first report

Use your coded project from section 4.

- [ ] Run a Code-Document Table by respondent group
- [ ] Export a Word report for one code group
- [ ] Write one draft finding supported by two quotations

REFERENCE

07 Good practice and quick reference

A coding workflow for evaluations

Prepare	Read	Code book	Code	Report
Anonymize, name files	2 or 3 transcripts	Deductive + inductive	All transcripts	Findings + quotes

BEFORE CODING

- [ ] Transcripts anonymized and named consistently
- [ ] Document groups set up
- [ ] Starting code book agreed with the team
- [ ] Every code has a definition
- [ ] Project saved in a secure folder

QUALITY CHECKS

- [ ] Two coders compare a sample transcript
- [ ] Duplicate codes merged
- [ ] Overloaded codes split
- [ ] Memos dated and linked to evidence
- [ ] Backup bundle exported daily

Key terms

Quotation
A marked passage of data that you want to analyze.

Code
A short label that tags quotations by topic or theme.

Code book
The list of codes with their definitions.

Memo
Your written notes and interpretations.

Code group
A set of related codes, such as all effectiveness codes.

Co-occurrence
When two codes are applied to the same or overlapping passages.